

Ant.Element

Social Entrepreneurship & Ecosystem Research

1. Project Overview

This report is adapted from the Marseille market study titled 'Marseille's Social & Creative Upcycling Businesses'. It examines three enterprises turning waste into social, environmental and economic value.

2. Context and Objectives

The study begins from the observation that Marseille's social economy is widely cited but thinly documented. The team went into the workshop environment to understand how these businesses actually operate, fund themselves and manage constraints.

1. Identify: scan Marseille's circular and social-economy scene and narrow it to businesses where environmental and social impact overlap.
2. Understand: meet founders in their own spaces and explore motivations and constraints.
3. Document: convert interviews into a reusable written study plus three video portraits.

3. Research Approach

4. Desk research: mapped associations, ateliers and creative founders and filtered candidates with real circular-economy models.
5. Case selection: chose three different models — a solo B2B workshop, a state-recognised insertion association and an independent creative founder.
6. On-site interviews: semi-structured interviews in French at each workshop.
7. Video & report: cross-read cases for shared patterns and packaged findings into report and video.

The methodology was chosen to capture narrative and field-level insight that quantitative data alone could not provide.

4. The Three Businesses

Atelier Royer — Elisabeth	Turns PVC banners bound for incineration into bags, accessories and furniture. Tension: scaling craft-level upcycling while keeping each piece unique and locally made.
13 A'tipik — Association	Uses a sewing workshop to retrain people far from employment due to disability, isolation or administrative hardship. Funded by upcycled-textile sales. Tension: balancing social mission and financial sustainability.
Zetapis — Anissa	Creates custom tufted rugs and upcycled sports gear and runs workshops supporting Marseille's craft scene. Tension: turning a personal creative practice into repeatable B2B partnerships.

5. Cross-Case Finding

The study's central finding is that upcycling is not the product — it is the bridge. Reusing waste allows founders to pursue a larger objective: a CSR offer for companies, a path back to work for marginalized people, or a distinctive creative identity.

- Environmental value: waste diverted.
- Social value: jobs and inclusion.
- Economic value: distinctive products.
- The common thread is narrative: funders and customers are presented as buying the story of transformation, not only the sustainability claim.

6. Results & Deliverables

Businesses studied	3 - Atelier Royer, 13 A'tipik and the third creative case listed on the deliverables slide as 'The Tappy'.
Founder video stories	3 - filmed on-site and subtitled in English.
Market report	10-page qualitative reference, co-written by the team.
Recommendations	Measure impact to attract capital; build cross-border partnerships; use FR/EN video and visuals to create an international pitch.

7. Recommendations

7.1 Measure to Attract Capital

Track kilos diverted, people supported and partnerships signed. The study frames measurable impact as useful because funders support what is countable.

7.2 Partner Across Borders

Link founders with European brands and events looking for circular solutions.

7.3 Tell the Story in Two Languages

Use French/English video and visual assets to turn local impact into an international pitch.

8. Team Learning and Contribution

The team concluded that impact at this scale can remain invisible until someone documents it. The contribution was therefore not simply analysis, but making three overlooked businesses more legible to a wider audience.

Nikita Patil - Scoped a broad brief into three answerable cases; selection was identified as the hardest analytical step.

Akanksha Joshi - Conducted trust-based interviews across a language barrier and drew out constraints founders do not always volunteer.

Rutwik Bhamare - Shaped hours of unscripted bilingual footage into a concise three-minute narrative.

9. Project Close & Handover

No successor team; the deliverables stand as a self-contained reference.

10-page report and three founder videos, archived and shareable.

Each business retains its own story and footage for self-promotion.

Public release planned pending founder consent.

10. Conclusion

The study presents three Marseille businesses as complementary examples of upcycling, textile insertion and creative craft. Its core contribution is documenting how environmental reuse can support wider social and economic value while translating founder stories into a reusable written and video reference